Family Communications Project: Comparing Child Behavior Outcomes in Same-Sex ART Families and Heterosexual ART families

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BACKGROUND

The Family Communication Project has been using the Family Communications Patterns Theory (FCPT) to look at families that have used assistive reproductive technologies (ART) to conceive children. It is important to have information on how these ART families are doing so that doctors, policy makers, insurance companies, and other families experiencing infertility can be informed when making decisions on laws, policies, and other aspects that may affect families who need assistive reproductive technologies. FCP has compared ART families to non-ART families, but FCP has not looked at how child external behavior outcomes differ among same-sex ART families and heterosexual ART.

PARTICIPANTS

Data analyzed for this study were based on the Family Communication Project's pilot study.

- Participants included all nine same-sex families from sample.
- Included nine heterosexual donor families and heterosexual non-donor families from sample.
- ART children were between the ages of 6-12.
- Children were on average 8.48 years old.
- All participants self-identified as Caucasian.



HYPOTHESIS

Controlling for the influence of parent child communication, children of same-sex ART couples will display different child externalizing behavior outcomes than children of heterosexual ART couples.

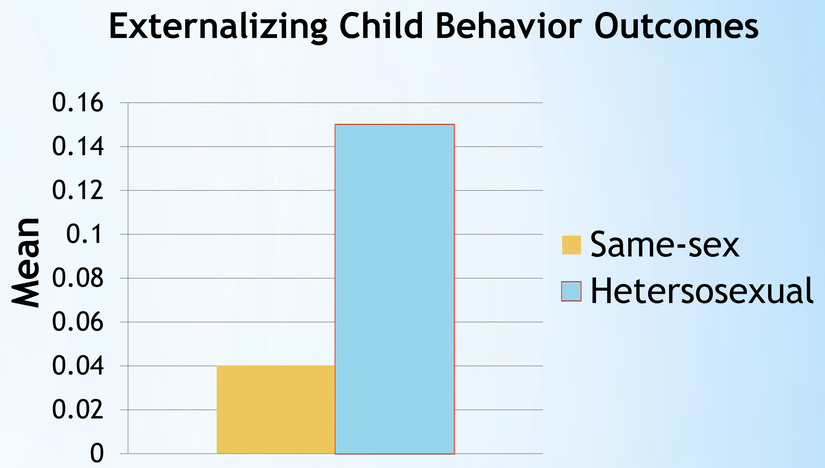
METHODS

Families were randomly selected. Participants completed the online survey using their home computers. Self reported externalized child behavior outcomes. FCPT was used to measure family communication, while items from the Child Behavior Checklist (CBCL) were used to measure externalizing child behavior outcomes. An ANCOVA was conducted using IBM SPSS version 19. Independence of observations was controlled using experimental control. The distribution was negatively skewed and unimodal. The mean of the externalizing behaviors scale was .08 (SD = 0.22). A Levene test was conducted to examine homogeneity of variance. The Levene test was not significant, indicating that the assumption was not violated. Missing data was addressed using listwise deletion, resulting in eight missing cases. In total, 11 cases were analyzed for this study.



RESULTS

There was a significant effect of the interaction between family communication and parent sexual orientation on childhood externalizing behaviors $F(1, .23) = 7.08$, $p < .05$. There is an effect of parent sexual orientation on childhood externalizing behaviors. Children of same sex parents demonstrated externalizing behaviors less frequently ($M = .04$, $SD = .10$), than those of heterosexual parents ($M = .15$, $SD = .34$), 95% CI. The effect size was ($\sigma = .09$), which is a small effect size (Cohen, 1992). Children in families with same sex parents reportedly demonstrated externalizing behaviors that were .09 less on the four-point scale than children from families headed by heterosexual parents.



DISCUSSION

The significant effect of the interaction between family communication and parent sexual orientation on childhood externalizing behaviors confirms what past research has concluded about same-sex families and child behavior outcomes. Parents sexual orientation and then the interaction between family communication and parent sexual orientation had a significant effect on externalizing child behavior outcomes however, family communication did not have a significant effect on child behavior outcomes. This may be because same-sex families are scrutinized more than heterosexual families; thus feel like they have to make more of an effort in communicating with their children. These results have rejected the null hypothesis.

LIMITATIONS

Limitations include the small sample size and parent self report on their children's external child behavior outcomes. External child behavior should be observed, or reported by the child. However, the ages of children in this study are still acceptable for parent self report. Future research should focus on recruiting more same-sex families for ART research.

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